

The Expression of Religious Identity in India: Evidence from 505 Million Voter Records

Feyaad Allie*
Viktor Enssle†
Tanushree Goyal‡
Saad Gulzar§
Gufran Pathan¶

RESEARCH NOTE

Abstract

We provide a theoretically grounded descriptive analysis of religious identity expression in India by examining personal names in over 505 million voter records. Standard theories of identity predict asymmetry: under rising discrimination, minorities should moderate visible markers while majorities express identity freely. In contrast, we find that both Hindus and Muslims show similarly high and increasing levels of religious distinctiveness in names. To characterize this rise, we examine the divine and social components of religious identity. We find no increase in doctrinally rooted names, inconsistent with growing religious devotion as an explanation. Instead, both groups increasingly draw from a smaller set of common names, and identity expression is stronger in segregated areas for the locally dominant group, highlighting the social function of religious identity. Together, these patterns reveal a precarious calculus in which minority moderation no longer holds, and cultural divides intensify alongside, and ahead of, majoritarian electoral politics

Keywords: Religious identity, inter-group relations, India, Hindu-Muslim relations, Social identity
Word count: 7671

* Assistant Professor, Department of Government, Harvard University

† PhD candidate, Department of Politics and International Relations and University College, University of Oxford

‡ Corresponding author, Assistant Professor, Department of Politics and School of Public and International Affairs, Princeton University

§ Associate Professor, Department of Politics and Keough School of Global Affairs, University of Notre Dame

¶ Research Associate, CEGA, University of California, Berkeley